



Becoming a linguist: advice from key thinkers in language studies

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BOOK REVIEW

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This wide-ranging collection of papers is both informative and helpful, specifically for students who are considering linguistics for research and teaching. Credit goes to the editors for inviting a broad range of viewpoints that reflect the controversies in the field – which have deepened in recent years. With different purposes in mind, the fifteen contributions highlight the evolution of sharp divisions. At the same time, the different perspectives allow us to understand them better and provide a welcome discussion. One set of chapters primarily traces the academic life of the author, each one featuring interesting reflections and perceptions. A second set presents three perspectives on the theoretical and applied commitments of linguistics as a field of study.

The first of the three perspectives represents the strong scientific paradigm, appropriately provided here by Noam Chomsky in Chapter 1. From this point of view, linguistics will make the most consistent progress as a branch of cognitive psychology, with empirical evidence continuing to lend support to the proposal of children's universal access to a faculty of language (FL) that guides the development of linguistic competence. Adult language learning also benefits from this access, but it is most strikingly revealed in young children's rapid, spontaneous and automatic mastery of their mother tongue grammar and lexicon. From the evidence of universality – which points to an inherited biological endowment specific to humans – follows the hypothesis that the core acquisition mechanisms of the FL are domain-specific. The broader *biolinguistics hypothesis* rejects the updated behaviourist/associationist theories of exclusively environmental conditioning and similar blank-slate shaping theories. While William Labov's Chapter 2 takes a different approach to research (sociolinguistic, in this case), and may not make use of the concept of a specialised FL, it embraces the same scientific method.

Chapter 2 also introduces the second group of perspectives on theory and application. Among the projects of Labov's research programme on language variation, his definitive finding regarding the grammatical well-formedness of African American Vernacular English contributed to correcting misconceptions that had negatively impacted language and literacy instruction. This approach explicitly focuses on problems of systematic denial of, or missed opportunity, or other types of prejudicial treatment affecting language use, especially in regard to learning. We apply the methods of science, or conduct fieldwork study that is compatible with these methods, with the ultimate purpose of reform and improvement. Most of the chapters more or less fall into this category as they depend, to one degree or another, on empirical investigation and the rules of evidence. In some cases, an inclination towards politicisation and racialisation tends to overshadow the actual questions of language science. Nevertheless, up until recent years, researchers have tried to maintain the underlying integrity of objective data-gathering and analysis, even when prior 'contextual considerations' present themselves as over-encompassing or determinant. It is fair to say that the effect of the latter has clearly gained ground, with mixed results.

In this regard, the research model illustrated in Chapters 1 and 2 rests upon the testing of a hypothesis that follows procedures of confirmation-disconfirmation. If predictions generated by the hypothesis *cannot be consistently verified*, it is either questioned or set aside. If assessment repeatedly results in tenuous findings, the hypothesis may be shown to be defective in some way. Empirical findings that are *reliably disconfirming* falsify it.

The third perspective qualitatively departs from the first two, and represents a historic break with the methods of modern science. Of recent emergence, the new paradigm can be traced to the theories of *post*-modern philosophy that seek to displace so-called Western rationality associated with objective inquiry.¹ Readers should note here that viewing post-modernism as non- or anti-scientific need not be seen as a criticism or a disqualification, as its anti-scientific assumptions are often embraced by leading exponents. In fact, its influence within the field of linguistics, particularly in the promotion of the idea of ‘translanguaging’, has become dominant in research on bilingual education and other sub-fields within applied linguistics – in pointed opposition to *scientism* (in its most negative connotation).

The chapters most representative of post-modern linguistics are those by Ofelia García, Alastair Pennycook and Robert De Costa. Versions of translanguaging typically take, as both their starting point and conclusion, an explicitly ideological motivation, guided by a ‘decolonising sensibility’. The sense that I gather from a careful reading of these three chapters is that the authors will agree – or accept with minor qualification – the distinction within linguistics today between positivist scientism and the conceptual framework of translanguaging and its allied ideological currents.² For example, the former might study the interaction among the language subsystems of the bilingual speaker as cognitively/psychologically real. In this case, the FL implements the interaction among autonomous linguistic domains. The latter has so far rejected the evidence for separate-interacting representations, in favour of the idea of languages as strictly socially constructed.

To recap, the division alluded to at the beginning of this review is, in abbreviated terms, between the scientific and the non-scientific. As a proposal for continued discussion, accepting this opposition will favour the mutual understanding of concepts and arguments. Alternatively, I may stand corrected and will welcome clarification.

Notes

1. The classification of ‘Western’ in reference to rational thinking requires extraordinary justification. In the same sense, ‘Western’ science is not a meaningful category.
2. Descriptions of translanguaging *theory* should not be confused with some of its *recommendations for teaching*, suggestions that most language educators would find unexceptional since they have been an integral part of accepted best practice for many years. This includes allowing students to freely make use of the totality of their linguistic capacity for learning; previously acquired discourse abilities, reliance on resources and concepts that facilitate cross-linguistic transfers, and so on.

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